

I, Robot— Your Friend

Robots are still considered largely outlandish, but advancements over the years may soon change that... and with it, probably the way we live

Aditya Kuber

Ever since science fiction took over the minds of inventors and the world at large, we have been yearning to create that perfect robot who would be our best friend, maid, pet, driver, vacuum cleaner... a veritable all-in-one that would rid us of having to do our daily chores, and not ask for leave either!

How close are we to this becoming a reality? Going by recent inventions and developments, not too far... robots are already beginning to walk, talk and yes, in some cases, even think like people.

Back in 1996, along with partner

Yoshihiro Kuroki, Tatsuzo Ishida, Sony Corp's ace robotics engineer suggested the creation of a new species of humanoid entertainment bots along the lines of C-3PO, the golden chatterbox in *Star Wars*. Creating robotic workers for factories is one thing, but the technical challenge of creating something like a humanoid is tremendous.

And what about the potential hazards that such a creature could pose? Until these creatures are smart enough to 'understand' what it's like to walk, they could just trip over and fall, injuring someone in their path and bring lawsuits against Sony in their wake!

Sony, though, decided to go in for the idea anyway. Thus was born the SDR or Sony Dream Robot. At a time when the world was gaping over Aibo, Sony's cute robotic puppy, Ishida and Kuroki were displaying half-a-dozen prototype humanoids at Yokohama at Robodex, an expo for personal robots.

